

roles in their villages, becoming their own best motivators.

Bharat Lal Meena, an IAS officer, who spent 14 years as deputy commissioner of Mangalore, and is currently the secretary of the Karnataka Social Welfare Department, is the man behind the mission. "If the onus to keep a place clean or save energy is upon the locals, then people take pride in themselves as they are the key stakeholders. They also tend to be less critical of the Government," says Meena, who introduced the Apna Desh formula wherever he served, including north and central Karnataka districts of Belgaum, Uttara Kannada, Karwar and Shimoga. Villagers working for free would band themselves under the Apna Desh banner, promoting community ownership of all public property like roads, street lights, drinking water facilities, schools

by stitching nearly 1,000 bags from old saris, while a rich farmer contributed 10 acres of land to the activities of the movement in the Dakshina Kannada region. For his endeavours, Meena received a call from the office of President, Pratibha Patil, wanting a low-down on the concept of Apna Desh and its impact in the villages that it had touched. Says A. Ebenezer, former principal of Bishop Cottons Boys School, about Meena's initiative, "This is like a social laboratory with things happening at the village level. With proper motivation and guidance, groups like Apna Desh play pivotal roles by complementing efforts of the government and pooling local resources for the good."

Apart from the movement, Meena has made a mark in the power sector as well. During his tenure at Bescom in Bangalore, he pushed the idea of light museums to be constructed on an eight-acre property near the city. As chairman of the state power transmission corporation, he scaled up power infrastructure projects (684 substations, 1.5 lakh distribution transformers and 3.57 lakh km LT lines) and brought down transmission and distribution (T&D) losses to the lowest in India—T&D losses cost the national exchequer Rs 1 lakh crore annually. Meena's initiatives resulted in zero

transformer failures for nearly three years and T&D losses at 9.5 per cent, the lowest of all power distributors in the country.

The Apna Desh concept has gained a foothold in several districts of the state, although Meena plays no direct role in them now. "When the stakeholders own the concept and projects at the micro-level, we don't have to worry as it is in safe hands," says Meena, after a visit to an Apna Desh-inspired tank conservation project in Shimoga district. The water tank in the Hunsinakatte village, on the outskirts of Shimoga, ran dry. The volunteers started working on desilting the water tank and improve water percolation and ground water recharge. Like in other Apna Desh instances, ownership means responsibility, which in turn means reliability and safety for the most deprived. Shimoga is a success, but for this Apna Aadmi, unless the concept is embraced by all, there is no resting easy. ■

People help best when they help themselves in improving their welfare and creating a positive environment around them.

BHARAT LAL MEENA,
Founder, Apna Desh



and sanitation outlets.

Meena, who comes from Sundari village in Sawai Madhapur, Rajasthan, completed a post-graduate degree in political science from the Rajasthan University and went on to gain another master's degree in rural development from the University of East Anglia in England. He climbed the ranks from the position of a clerk in the Reserve Bank of India in 1980 to an IAS officer, four years later, by sheer dint of hard work.

A freely downloadable concept, the Apna Desh movement, says Meena, is a template that will work anywhere in the world. "The whole idea is to manage local affairs by the locals, leveraging the resources of the government," he adds. The impact of his initiative has been widespread, ranging from projects like cloth bags, sanitation to building anganwadi centres in government schools. One of the volunteers in a village made a record



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